AN UN-NATURAL PROCESS OF DECAY

Narrating the Afterlife of Demolished Architecture



Figure 1.
Author's photograph

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Figure 2.
Author's photograph

ABSTRACT

"An Un-natural Process of Decay", a thesis project completed within the Master's Programme in Spatial Design at Konstfack, Stockholm, began in the autumn of 2025, with the demolition of a postmodern parking garage in the city-satellite Marievik. Four people and two bulldozers demolished 25% of the structure within a period of 48 hours. Equally fast, the demolition continued and I spent time during those days alongside the building, the remains of it and my reflections around its life and value.

This project treats the parking garage as the subject of a personal and architectural exploration of the life and death of a building. As demolition unfolded, the project shifted from documenting to speculating – asking what values remain after the physical building structure is erased.

Among the thinkers that informed this project, the architect Sam Jacob served as a particularly important theoretical reference. Drawing on his book *Make it Real, Architecture as Enactment* (Jacob, 2012) as well as his essay "Doppelgänger" in "Under the Influence" (Miljački, 2014, p. 87), - the project developed a methodological approach that centred on re-enactment and iteration. further exploring how these strategies could be activated when composing the afterlife of demolished architecture.

The exploration was structured around isolating fragments from the previous building, iterating them through hand-drawings and models, and subsequently re-activating them within speculative spatial contexts. The result was ultimately not a finished object but rather the articulation of a method embodied through a speculative future scenario in which the afterlife of architecture could be an ongoing process of exploration.

MARIEVIK – A SITE OF CONSTANT CHANGE

In the early autumn, I stepped foot in Marievik for the first time that I can remember. A neighbourhood crowded with office buildings, contemporary residential blocks, and ongoing construction, it appeared to promise constant transformation. In a mechanical way, Marievik seemed to follow the tick of an invisible clock. Weekdays were crowded with people in work attire, in a range from black/grey suits to bright green tech jackets, pacing the streets like hectic pixels. Weekends, however, were as still as could be – a ghost town really. I understood these conditions as evidence of a strictly work-based way of life: a portrait of the disciplined human.

It is undoubtedly hard to imagine Marievik ever settling for a fixed form or identity, yet this constant transformation might embody the very essence of the place. A product of its ideal location as a sliver of land, sprung in-between the waterfront quay and the old industrial railway tracks stretching from Liljeholmen to Södra Station, it became a perfect site for industrial development - an entity directly shaped by fluctuations of production and economy (Bach, Amaral & Edman 2024, p. 66). The history of Marievik is recounted in the book *Arkitekturen i Omprövningens Tid* (Bach, Amaral & Edman 2024). Following the post-industrial turning-point occurring in alignment with the economic crisis during the 1970s, they paint the picture of an area undergoing identity reconstruction.

The glory days of the steel industry, which had previously been prominent in the area, came to an end due to economic constraints and key stakeholders occupying the land redirected focus towards real estate trading – selling the image of Marievik as a lovechild of the emerging ideal of the modern workplace (ibid, p.67). These ideas came to form alongside the drafts of a new local plan introduced in 1989 by DOM Borowski Architects and property owner, Stancia AB. Under this plan, wholesale warehouses either were transformed, demolished or accompanied by new buildings to sustain modern office spaces (ibid, p. 67).

At the heart of the new plan was the idea that architecture could serve as a key component of corporate marketing strategies in the formation of company identities and branding. This prompted a vision of architecturally distinctive buildings, capable of embodying company values – visually symbolising success and innovation. As these ambitions coincided with the economic boom of the 1980s, the new Marievik began to take shape as a product of the era's visionary ideals and aspirations. Today it stands as a prominent site of Postmodern architecture (ibid. p. 67)



Render by Stockholms Stad - Stockholm Växer
(Stockholms Stad 2026)



Figure 4.
Author's photograph

THE SUBJECT – AXELSSON & BOROWSKI´S PARKING GARAGE

As of this writing, Marievik is yet again on the tipping-point of change. Among the key actors shaping this transformation are the property owners, AMF Fastigheter, Klövern and JM. (Stockholms Stad, 2019). Through utopian renderings communicated on their websites as well as on the website of Stockholms Stad, it is possible to glimpse their vision for the future. With high-rise structures housing modern office-spaces, residential apartments and a hotel overlooking Södermalm and Tantolunden (Stockholms stad, 2019), the urban typology emerging from this future scenario appears almost like a microcosm, borrowed from a skyscraper city.

Among the otherwise scaffold-clad buildings, I found comfort in the exposed and raw exterior of a parking garage sprung between two office buildings along the northern quay. It was an arrangement of red bricks contrasted by bright blue railings lining each opening in the façade, creating the impression of an over-scaled woven pattern, set against the buildings around it. It was a rigid body with awkward angles and a symmetry that was ninety per cent flawless and, in the remaining ten per cent, completely off - as if a mistake had been made in the blueprint and deemed unworthy of correction. I came to take photographs of this building in an attempt to understand its composition, and with time they accumulated into a small collection that I began to treasure.

Designed by Axelsson & Borowski Architects in 1989, the parking garage stands as an example of postmodern architecture (Bach, Amaral & Edman 2024, p.76), depicting a play on opposing forms, seemingly allowing for moments of 'fun' in contrast to its practical function. Like any building of its typology, the parking garage was equipped to serve a specific purpose, expressed through its prominent helix ramp, low ceiling heights and slightly sloping floors. Together, these features composed an architecture that I began to perceive as stubborn – an obsolete utility building that, in its unwillingness to transform into something it was not originally intendent to be, appeared the most honest and sincere.

Perhaps it was precisely this stubbornness that drew me to it. In an area otherwise characterised by buildings under construction or redevelopment, I came to think of the garage as a force of resistance to the changes unfolding around it. I was captivated by its silence and sense of abandonment in a place where everything else seemed to embody the opposite. Within this context, the garage stood almost as a sanctuary, seemingly untouched and monument-like in its presence.

I continued expanding my collection of photographs, and over time they became evidence of a growing acquaintance. Filtered through my own biased perception, the collection became a tool for communicating what I had found in the building to others. Gradually, Axelsson & Borowski's garage turned into the protagonist of my documentation and the central figure through which this project constructs its narrative.



Figure 5.
Konstfack Spring Exhibition, author's photograph



Figure 6.
Author's photograph



Figure 7.
Author's photograph

A CONFLICT OF VALUE

A pivotal moment for both the project and myself, occurred in the late autumn of 2025 when I became aware that Axelsson & Borowski´s parking garage was facing demolition as result of the new local development plan, making way for a 27-story apartment building (Bach, Amaral and Edman, 2024; Klövern, 2026) Shortly thereafter the demolition process began, and in response I became convinced that the project needed to address and document the building's decay. On a personal level, this impulse stemmed from an attachment to the garage, an attachment that perhaps found legitimacy through the formal framework of a thesis project.

As the documentation progressed, I discovered that the parking garage had been green-listed by the Stockholm City Museum´s cultural heritage department. Ironically this designation stood in direct opposition to its approaching erasure from the perspective of preserving cultural heritage. The museum describes the classification as follows: "Green indicates that the property contains structures of particular value from a historical, cultural-historical, environmental, or artistic perspective" (authors own translation from: "Grönt betyder att fastigheten har bebyggelse som är särskillt värdefull från historiskt, kulturhistoriskt miljömässig eller konstnärlig synpunkt," (Stadsmuseet, 2026).

A conflict therefore emerged between recognised cultural value and planned demolition, leading this project to question how value is produced and what forms of value are prioritised within contemporary society.

This particular case demonstrates how economic and practical values can supersede the institutional recognition of cultural and architectural heritage. Critically, it suggests that heritage can become negotiable when confronted with sufficiently strong economic interests. As a result, the demolition of the garage, alongside other buildings holding similar heritage status, appears to undermine the authority of the very systems intended to recognise and protect cultural value. This caused further reflection on how urban transformation in terms of construction and demolition does in fact establish the existence of a 'value-hierarchy'. More broadly, I speculate that these processes shape public perceptions of what constitutes valuable architecture. particularly if there exists an identifiable pattern behind decisions concerning preservation and demolition.

Similar cases are currently unfolding elsewhere in Marievik. One example is along the northern quay, where 32.700 sqm of office space was demolished in 2023 by the property owner JM, and on the official website of ACAN (Architects! Climate, Action, Network, Sverige) it is possible to read about the architectural significance of the building that ones stood there (ACAN, Rivningskartan, 2026; Stockholms stad 2019). The motivation text, along with the very existence of ACAN, proposes a



Figure 8.
Author's photograph

counter-position to the conflict described above. On their website, they uplift and problematize the current demolition frenzy, making it difficult not to mention the organisation alongside movements such as Arkitektupproret or Renoveringsraseriet, when discussing the current architectural discourse in Sweden.

Despite their differences in tone and method, these initiatives undoubtedly share a common concern for the loss of historical environments and architectural continuity. These concerns may also be understood in relation to earlier cycles of urban transformation, for example in the debate surrounding the demolition of the Klara neighbourhood in Stockholm 1975, which raised many of the same questions that continue to surface today.

Reflecting on their shared position led me to consider where my own project finds itself within this discourse - especially as the protagonist of my investigation cannot be saved from physical erasure. This raised a further question;

If architectural and cultural values can no longer attach themselves to a physical structure, can they continue to exist through representation, narrative, and re-enactment? What follows naturally is the question of whether demolished architecture can continue to persist through such re-enactments in a meaningful way?



Figure 9.
Author's photograph

ARCHITECTURE BETWEEN MYTH AND REALITY

"The constant re-iteration of architecture multiples its sense of reality. We might even say that architecture only achieves its reality through replication, when its forms, aesthetics or materialities appear in multiple sites, to the point where its qualities achieve total ubiquity – and architecture becomes a totalised environment on a planetary scale" (Sam Jacob, 2012, p.12).

In the search for a methodological approach capable of responding to the question I had formulated, I stumbled upon the work of London based architect Sam Jacob. In his book *"Make it Real, Architecture as Enactment"* (Jacob, 2012), he writes on the theme of architecture in relation to myth, reality and the intersection between the two. The opening quotation is taken from the first chapter, in which he describes architecture as 'real fictions' offering an initial glimpse of his understanding of architecture and its modes of existence.

To understand his definition of myth and reality, Jacob explains that the mythological refers to the ideas, ideologies, meanings and beliefs that shape our cultural narratives in which we, in turn, create, communicate and think. In contrast, he defines the real as the physical and empirically observable aspects of our environment - things that can be measured and experienced through materiality. (Jacob, 2012, p.29). The interesting matter of his book is when he attempts to situate the nature of architecture in the context of these two worlds. He arrives to what he calls the 'special condition of architecture', essentially meaning that architecture can be both the thing and the representation of the thing at the same time. This, he explains, is because architecture exists in the loop of constant re-enactment of both itself as well as the history, culture and society that caused its upbringing. Biased to its context, architecture manifests these narratives into the real world through its physical presence, and this is where it becomes both real and fictional at the same time (Jacob, 2012, p.10).

Through the theoretical lens that Jacob provides, it becomes interesting to think about the aspect of an architectural afterlife. If architecture already exists in the grey zone between physical reality and fictional representation, its disappearance from one of the realms, arguably does not hinder it from continuing to exist in the other. In the event of demolition, as in the case of Axelsson & Borowski´s garage, the physical structure disappears, but the narratives and values attached to it, remain. Even the act of demolition itself can be understood as an enactment of societal value systems. The interesting question that follows is whether the values previously manifested through the architecture needs to be sustained through other forms of media once the physical body anchoring them to reality, is erased. Revisiting the current social discourse discussed earlier, and the

scarceness of loosing architectural continuity to the forces of economy and practicality – it might be more important than ever to find ways in which demolished architecture can continue to persist and remain meaningful.

Alongside these reflections, and together with the personal sorrow of witnessing the death of my favourite parking garage, I searched for a source of comfort, and I found it in philosopher Michael Serres theory of the quasi object in which similarities can be drawn to Jacob's writings as well. In brief, Serres describes the quasi-object not as a fixed entity or object, but as something that exists because it acquires meaning through its relations and interactions with external actors and society (Otero-Pailos, J., Langdalen, E. and Arrhenius, T, 2016, p, 16). While Jacob states that architecture legitimises itself through ways of repetition, Serres suggests that meaning and value are generated through participation in social discourse. Where they bridge, is in the understanding that architectural presence (and other presences for Serres) is not solely dependent on physical permanence. Rather, it can continue to exist as something equally real and meaningful through representation, discourse, and other forms of mediation.

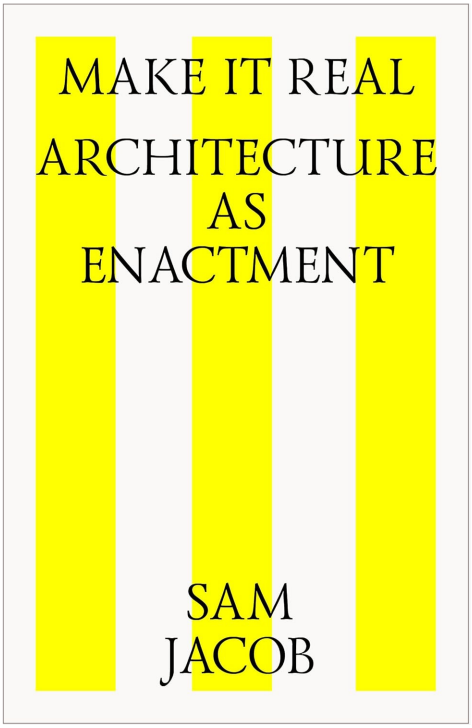


Figure 10. Cover of the book:
Make it Real, Architecture as Enactment



Figure 11.
Photo: © Harry Gruyaert / Magnum Photos
Gordon Matta-Clark, Untitled (Anarchitecture), 1975. ADAGP, Paris

GORDON MATTA-CLARK, PRESERVATION WITHOUT PHYSICAL PRESENCE

A prominent example that embodies the idea of architectures presence beyond the physical body is the work of American artist and architect Gordon Matta-Clark (1943-1978). During the 1970s, he was known for a series of radical cuts and interventions done to abandoned building and urban ruins in cities such as Paris, Antwerp and Chicago (Lee, 2000, p, 2). With the original structures having long since disappeared, his interventions survive solely through documented videos and photographs. As a result, his work enters an afterlife in which the buildings are remembered through the art performed upon them, whose erasure forms part of their meaning. The representation of his work through these 'techno-physical' media concludes the story about his interventions, and this 'afterlife' still causes for socio-relevant reflection and sentiment towards the ones existing buildings.

Pamela Lee's book *Object to be destroyed* (Lee, 2000), offers an in-depth description of the work of Matta-Clark. Within it, she identifies a much compelling layer to his work, stating that; "Because Matta-Clark's work presupposes its own destruction, it internalizes this historical loss, this entropic remove. In doing so, it is a monument to the very pretensions of the monument, becoming itself site-less in the process" (Lee, 2000 p. 38). The site-less monument or the 'non-ument', which was the term used by Matta-Clark himself is, in its brilliant phrasing, profoundly contradictory which perhaps makes it more intriguing. It suggests that the radical interventions he made to abandoned buildings, already had accepted their temporality in the physical world. However, the term 'non-ument' through its obvious reference to the monument simultaneously implies a desire of continuity.

Pamela Lee further situates Matta-Clark's work within the broader currents of 1970s conceptual art, through which she offers an understanding of the temporality of his practice. In relation to tendencies among other contemporary artists of the time, she describes a climate shaped by the idea of dematerializing the art object, visible through for example "Idea Art", "Post-Object Art", "Anti-Object Art", and "Post-Aesthetic Art" (Lee , p. 14). These positions collectively suggests that the finished object is already "dead" and that the process is what matters. Given that Matta Clark was influenced by these currents, provides an understanding of his work as a development of a practice and a method rather than a finished object or isolated intervention (ibid.). Furthermore, this also reshapes how the afterlife of his work can be understood. The afterlife does not document or preserve a finished entity, but rather it seems to have captured a process, a method and an ongoing practice.

This raises the question of whether this is exactly where the persistent value in his work lies. Rather than being approached with a 'dead' finished object, we are exposed to the documentation of a process that never seems to end. In this sense, the afterlife of his work is not existing as a static entity, but rather as an active point of reflection, that allows it to continue finding relevance even in the discourse of present time.

In conclusion, the perspective being brought to me by Jacob, Serres and Matta-Clark made me understand demolition not necessarily as a terminating force that has the power to end the 'realness' of architecture, but as transformative state that causes it to enter another realm. The other realm, hereby mentioned as the 'afterlife' also acquires a new perspective through the lens of these sources, Sam Jacob and Matta-Clark especially. Equal to how Jacob describes that architecture stays relevant in the physical world because it constantly re-invents itself through re-enactment – the representation of the ones existing architecture reasonably must act under the similar circumstances.

Consequently, the ambition of this project is not to find a static answer on how to represent Axelsson & Borowski's garage – but rather to develop a method where the representation is allowed to re-enact and reinterpret itself because it would follow the very nature of how physical architecture behaves.

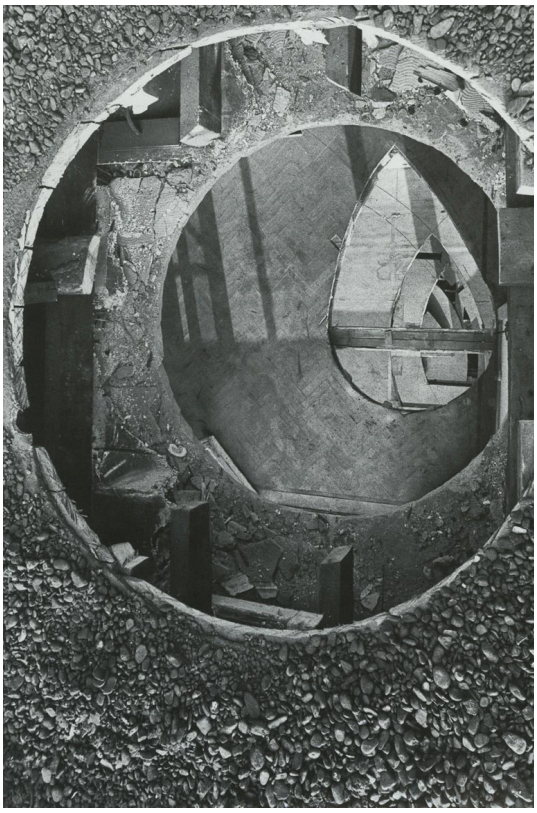


Figure 12.
Photo: Marc Petitjean
Gordon Matta-Clark. Conical intersect, Paris. 1975.
Museu d'Art Contemporani de Barcelona

THE COPY AS METHOD

With the previous conclusion, guiding the idea that re-enactment used as an active design strategy could be a way to make even the representation of architecture claim its reality and relevance, drew me towards another text written by Sam Jacob. In the book *Under the Influence* (Miljački, 2014) where he contributes with the essay "Doppelgänger" (Jacob, 2014), speaking on the copy as a phenomenon that not merely seek to replicate the original, but unexpectedly transmits new values through its attempt and failure to do so, He explains this through the example of Villa Rotunda (Andrea Palladio), comparing the original architecture in relation to the many Sketch-up model copies that has been made of it, He states: "Running through the process is the idea of transmission: the fact that you take one thing and, as you move it to another media or another technology, from digital to physical, it both loses a certain amount of information and gains something else through the process" (Jacob, 2014, p 88).

His text led me to understand the copy as a method to move forward rather then merely a tool for replication, and it became a strategy that I adopted as a starting point for the project. This following section examines the design process in relation to the idea of the copy and, subsequently, the re-enactment of that copy within new spatial contexts.

Copying as a Way of Keeping

Initially, I copied Axelsson & Borowski's garage by hand, drawing an axonometric view based on the reference of the original floorplan and section produced by the architects. Somehow it became an outlet of the urge to depict the building, as it was intended, before it disappeared. The act of drawing by hand, allowed me to copy the building through a medium of which I could be fully present. It was not as much about completing the drawing as it was about using it as a tool to become familiar with what I was observing.

Isolating fragments

Copying, without adding, led me to understand the components of which the parking garage was composed, and their function within the larger whole. As the demolition unfolded, I discovered new components and observed them being detached from their original positions, as though the building were a body cracking open to reveal its skeleton. This transformative condition, consequently separated building fragments from their expected context, in a sense, allowing them to have agency as singular objects rather than merely functioning as a part of the larger structure. I wanted to explore this condition further by separating the fragments from one another, which I did by printing my photographs I had taken and systematically cutting them out from their background.

The fragments within new spatial settings

The act of isolating the fragments allowed me to view them more as objective material that could be copied, and re-enacted. In some ways, I thought of this process as analogous to spolia in Late Antiquity, when architectural artefacts could be removed from their original context and objectivley reused as material within new constructions.

This understanding led to a process in which I felt authorised to copy and iterate the fragments through different media, particularly through model-making and hand drawing. With each iteration, I discovered new ways of contextualising the fragments, whether through patternmaking, collage, or speculative model compositions.

The outcome of this exploration was the development of a repetitive process in which I systematically copied a fragment, used it as a guide for shaping the surrounding space, and subsequently re-evaluated it through its new context.

One example emerged through the iteration of the garage's structural columns. I constructed spaces around their form to the point where the column was no longer perceived as a structural element, but instead appeared as signage or as a symbolic object within its new context (Figure 13, 14, 15).

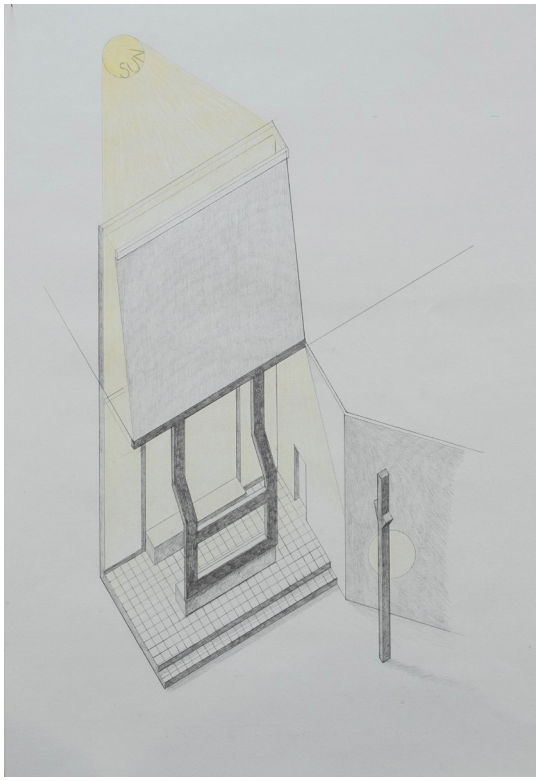


Figure 13.
Axonometric blyetch drawing, scale 1:50 on A2 paper

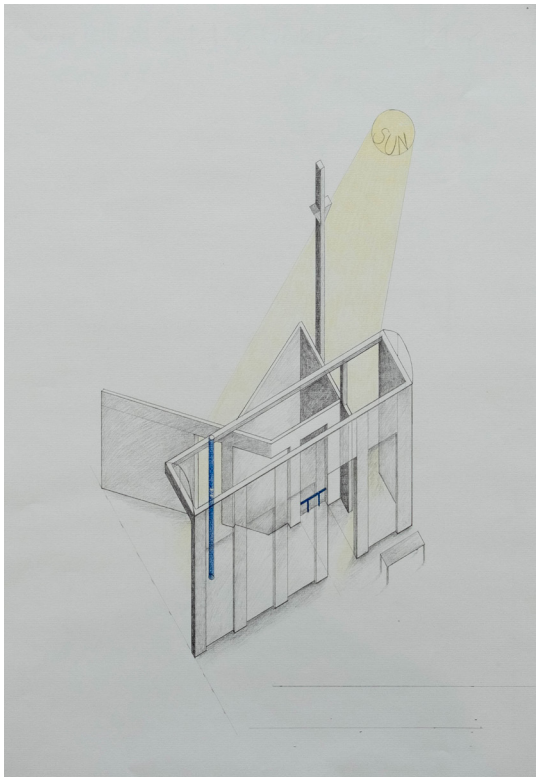


Figure 14.
Axonometric blyetch drawing, scale 1:50 on A2 paper

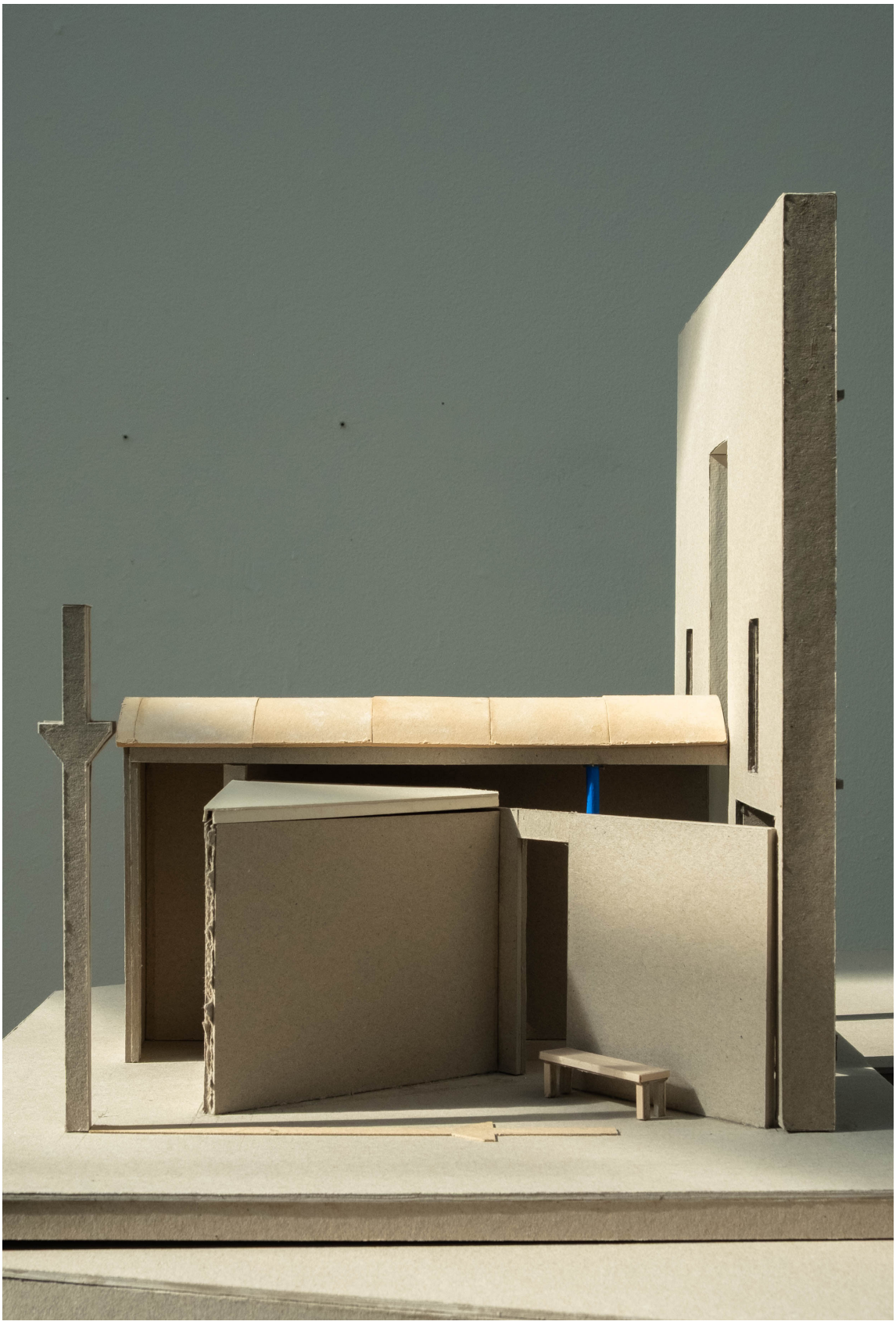


Figure 15.
Model scale 1:25

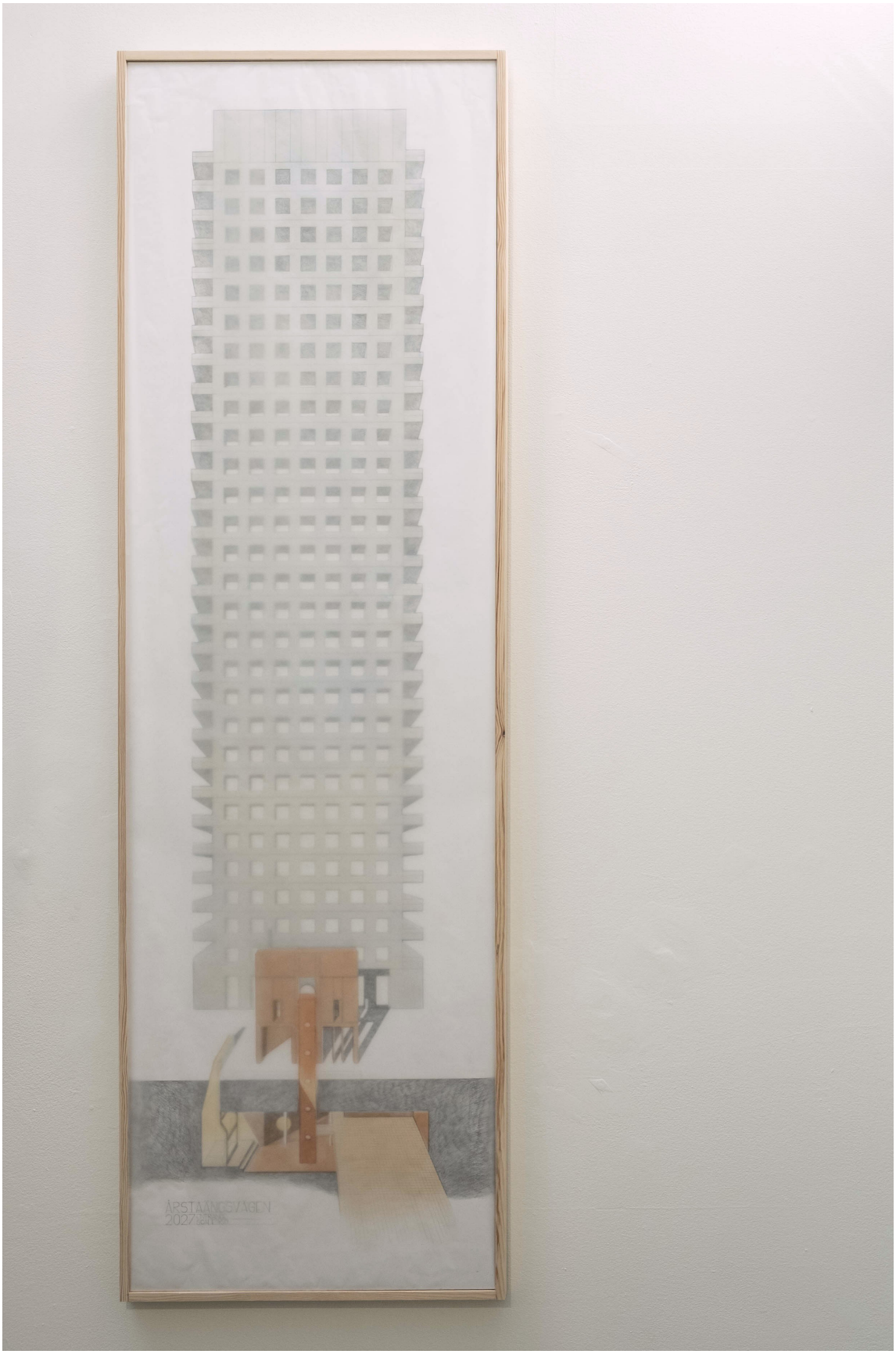


Figure 16.
4. Konstfacks Vårutställning 2026, Dawing (scale 1.50), 220x70 cm. Blyetch and pigment powder on sketchpaper.

The speculative scenario

As I accumulated a collection of modelled and hand-drawn spaces shaped through the guidance of copied fragments, I began to speculate about the larger context in which these spatial conditions could exist.

As mentioned earlier in the section “A Conflict of Value”, the site where Axelsson & Borowski’s garage once stood is scheduled to be occupied by a 27-storey apartment building in 2027. This very real future became the setting upon which my speculative future could unfold. Lacking precise knowledge of how much land the new development would occupy, I instead envisioned my project existing beneath the ground, with only its entrance remaining visible above the surface. The intention behind this placement was also to draw a subtle parallel to forms of decay found in nature. When a plant dies, its decomposition allows it to become part of a larger cycle, gradually returning to the earth while remaining connected to what it once was. The synthetic decay of demolition, however, arguably denies such circularity.

I therefore began to imagine my speculative scenario as a re-enactment of this cycle. Within it, the afterlife I had constructed for Axelsson & Borowski’s parking garage would continue to exist beneath the ground where the building once stood (figure 16). Yet rather than physically returning to the earth, the architecture of the garage reappears through the narratives and re-enactments that together construct its afterlife.

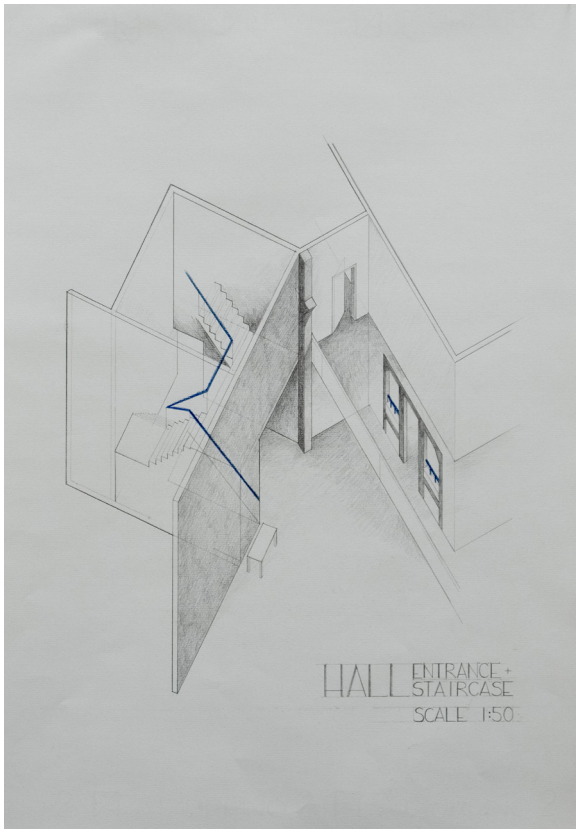


Figure 17.
Axonometric blyetch drawing, scale 1:50 on A2 paper

CONSTRUCTING THE AFTERLIFE OF DEMOLISHED ARCHITECTURE

The result of my project translated into a speculative future scenario, in which re-enacted fragments of Andersson & Borowski's parking garage were depicted through models and hand-drawings that ultimately constructed a new spatial setting. The outcome may be understood as a design proposal; however, I perceive it primarily as the development of a method or strategy for approaching demolished architecture, and the values lost in the process of its erasure.

This project initially asked what happens If architectural and cultural values can no longer attach themselves to a physical structure, and if they can continue to exist through representation, narrative, and re-enactment in a meaningful way. In response to this question, the text has sought validation for the idea that architecture can continue to matter even after its physical presence has disappeared. In doing so, I have drawn upon texts by Sam Jacob to support my claim, yet in retrospect, there are several aspects that suggests that the arguments presented here needs to be more nuanced.

Just as Jacob writes about the intersection of myth and reality of in which architecture exists, he also acknowledges the unique power of architecture in its physical form. Throughout this project, I have argued that demolition could be understood as a transformative state, where architectural values can continue to persist and matter through representational forms. However, I now find this claim to underestimate the power that architecture holds as a physical enactment of law and social structures – something any representational form arguably can never replicate.

This reflection raises a further question: in what realm the architectural afterlife actually exists and if it can matter within the social discourse in the same way as the architecture it represents? The answer I have arrived at is that it probably cannot. Yet this does not erase the fact that its existence is important. Like any other expression of culture, architecture tells us something about the way we live, our presence and history. In the event of demolition, such understandings risk being lost if not preserved or represented.

I believe this project to have been a wish to make that representation relevant within a social discourse, so that demolished architecture might not be forgotten - particularly in a time characterised by increasing urban transformation. What I believe to have learned, especially in reference to Matta-Clark is that this representation might never be a finished entity but rather understood as a form of ongoing maintenance job; a garden that needs tending or a house that needs to be repainted.

The ultimate component causing this representation to be relevant over time, is that it mimics the exact way that architecture becomes real (according to Jacob). It re-invents itself through re-enactment. Consequently, the architectural afterlife can never be a finished entity but rather, it must continually re-invent itself in order to maintain its relevance – just as the enduring afterlife of Gordon Matta-Clark's work.

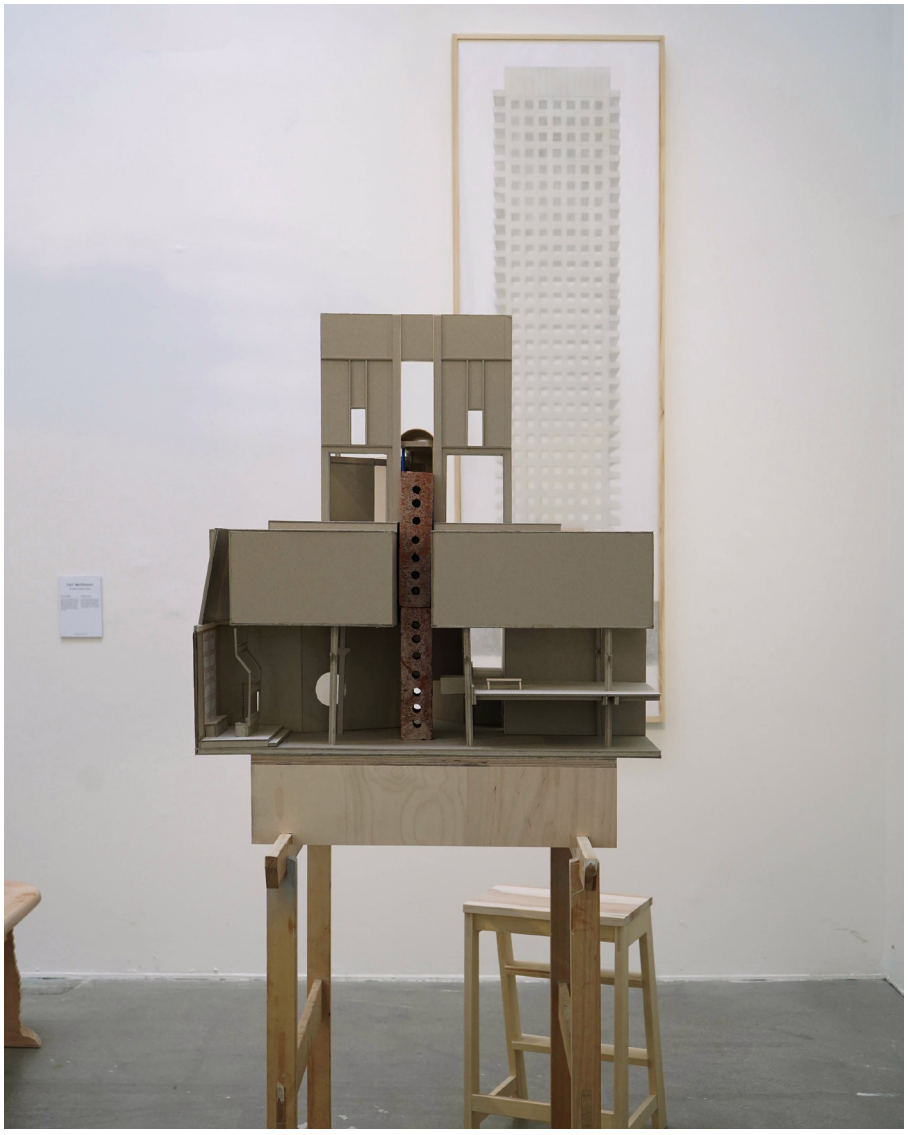


Figure 18.
Konstfacks Vårutställning - Model scale 1:25

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IMAGE SOURCES

Following figures are the author's own photographs as well as motives in terms of drawings and models.
Figure 1,2,4,5,6,7,8,12,13,14,15,16, 17

Figure 3: Render published by Stockholms stad (2026) Bostäder, kontor och förskolor i Marievik. Stockholm Växer. Available at: https://vaxer.stockholm/projekt/liljeholmen/bostader-kontor-och-forskolor-i-marievik/ (Accessed: 3 June 2026).

Figure 10: Jacob, S. (2012), Cover Page of: *Make It Real: Architecture as Enactment*. Moscow: Strelka Press.

Figure 11: Gordon Matta-Clark, Untitled (Anarchitecture),
Rue Beaubourg, 1975, Photo: © Harry Gruyaert / Magnum Photos

Figure 12: Gordon Matta-Clark. Conical intersect, Paris. 1975. Museu d'Art Contemporani de Barcelona
Photo: Marc Petitjean